

Suspect at golf club was Marine

Jeanine John Taele has history of honors and charges before arrest at Trump’s course.

By CLARA HARTER, RICHARD WINTON AND TERRY CASTLEMAN

For nearly a decade, Jeanine John Taele was a U.S. Marine with tours in both Iraq and Afghanistan.

Until July 2025, the Downey resident was licensed to work as an armed security guard.

Then, over the last few days, authorities allege he twice roamed the grounds of Trump National Golf Club in advance of a presidential visit, wearing a radio earpiece, taking photos of Secret Service agents on the grounds and carrying a round of ammunition in his pocket. Taele was arrested Sunday during his second visit to the golf course. Authorities said they discovered a small cache of firearms at his home along with a security ID.

In federal court, Taele is charged with possession of an unregistered short-barreled rifle, a felony that carries a maximum sentence of 10 years in prison. His court appearance was rescheduled from Wednesday to an undetermined date.

His motives for being on the exclusive oceanside club grounds in Rancho Palos Verdes remain unclear. But the case is generating close attention given two earlier attempts on President Trump’s life — the first in Butler, Pa., and another weeks later on a golf course in Florida.

Taele’s movements over the last few years are hard to piece together. But beyond the federal charge, he also faces state-level charges of receiving a large-capacity magazine, carrying a concealed weapon, possession of a short-barreled rifle and robbery, according to the criminal complaint filed by the Los Angeles County district attorney’s office. According to El Segundo Police Lt. Eric Atkinson, on Nov. 4, Taele committed a strong-armed robbery in which he used force or fear rather

[See **Marine**, A6]



Photographs by RONALDO BOLAÑOS Los Angeles Times

FILMMAKERS with smaller budgets lose out on existing film incentives built for larger projects. Above, director Vanna James on set for “The Seed.”

L.A. aims to hold on to indie film production

Proposed grants would fund low-budget projects

By CERY S DAVIES

Independent filmmaker Sylvia Ray always wanted to shoot her first feature film, “The Middle,” in California — as it’s set in Barstow, where she grew up.

Instead, she shot it in Mexico.

The math made the decision for her. Grants and incentives from the municipality of Torreón and the state of Coahuila covered 30%-40% of her production budget, which came in under a million dollars, Ray said, adding that she didn’t have to pay for film permits, on-site security or local hotel accommodations.

Over 21 days in March and April, the production hired 75 local crew members and college students.

“All I needed was a desert landscape and American homes. I could have definitely shot it in L.A. comfortably. Had I gotten more support and made it make sense for us financially,” Ray said. “But it just didn’t.”

Her budget was too small to qualify for any California film incentive at the time,

as the state’s program doesn’t reach projects costing under \$1 million.

Low-budget filmmakers and producers say that gap is a major problem. California’s incentives, even after the recent expansion, are built for productions several rungs above them.

Los Angeles County has plans to change that.

Supervisors Lindsey Horvath and Kathryn Barger are developing an Entertainment Evergreen Fund, first introduced last July, which would channel money to productions the state’s tax credit doesn’t reach.

The fund would distribute grants rather than tax credits.

No dollar amount has been attached and the county has not committed funding.

The board intends to explore a public-private model, with funding sources, amounts and any cost sharing determined only af-

[See **Films**, A11]

Utilities urge state to limit fire liability

PG&E, Edison prod Legislature to adopt rules that would help protect shareholders.

By MELODY PETERSEN

Top executives of California’s two biggest utilities warned they would take action to protect their shareholders if Sacramento lawmakers fail to pass legislation limiting their companies’ liabilities for wildfires sparked by their equipment.

“If the Legislature does not act, or if they act and don’t actually solve the problem, then we’re going to have to take action,” said Patti Poppe, chief executive of Pacific Gas & Electric, on a July 23 call with Wall Street analysts.

Poppe did not specify what her company would do, but made it clear any action would protect shareholders’ money. Previously, she told Wall Street analysts that if lawmakers failed to pass legislation to protect the utilities, PG&E would use its cash to buy back the compa-

ny’s shares, according to a report by the bank Jeffries.

That could raise the company’s stock price and benefit shareholders, while reducing money available for the utility’s California programs.

The comments from Poppe and Pedro Pizarro, chief executive of Edison International, came just before the state Legislature returned from summer break Monday to begin the last four weeks of its session.

Gov. Gavin Newsom and legislators have been working behind closed doors to

address the state’s escalating cost of wildfires, including those caused by the utilities. The Times reported last month. The big electric companies have told their investors they are talking to Newsom and lawmakers about a bill package that would protect shareholders from paying for utility-sparked fires.

On Tuesday, government fire officials released their investigation into last year’s devastating Eaton fire, blaming Edison’s century-old transmission line, which

[See **Utilities**, A10]

Sheriff’s commander exits job amid probe

Internal report says he misled officials about a subordinate. He blamed bad memory.

By ALENE TCHEKMEDYAN

A commander of an elite Los Angeles County sheriff’s unit ignored evidence that cleared a subordinate of wrongdoing and went after him anyway — and then provided “false or misleading” statements about it

under oath, an internal investigation found.

Top brass recommended that Cmdr. Oscar Barragan, who oversaw the agency’s special enforcement bureau, be discharged for violating the department’s policies on dishonesty and obstructing an investigation, according to an internal July 14 memo reviewed by The Times.

A sheriff’s spokesperson said Barragan “separated” from the department two weeks before the memo was issued. She declined to elaborate.

Barragan did not respond to a request for comment. In an internal interview with sheriff’s investigators, he blamed his bad memory and denied intentionally providing false or misleading testimony.

The special enforcement bureau, which handles high-risk tactical operations such as barricaded suspects and hostage situations, has been at the center of several recent controversies. Last year, a grenade exploded at a training facility, killing three bomb squad detectives. The explosion

prompted multiple investigations — one into the deputies’ deaths, another into the disappearance of a second grenade and a third into the alleged distribution of graphic crime scene photos of the detectives’ bodies. A state investigation, meanwhile, found a series of safety violations, including failure to provide effective training.

In another case involving the bureau, a black Labrador named Spike who was trained to detect fire accelerants in arson investiga-

[See **Investigation**, A7]

For Democrats, a struggle over party’s identity

A progressive’s Senate primary victory in swing state Michigan presents a crucial test.

By CHRISTOPHER BUCHANAN AND JUSTINE MCDANIEL

WASHINGTON — The narrow victory of progressive doctor Abdul El-Sayed in Michigan’s bitterly fought Democratic Senate primary sets up a defining test of the party’s progressive wing in one of the highest-stakes U.S. Senate contests of the midterms.

Whether El-Sayed, a former public health official, can carry swing voters in a battleground state could both determine the outcome of a Senate seat viewed as crucial to determining control of Congress and have broader ramifications on the Democratic Party’s struggle for its identity.

El-Sayed, a 41-year-old epidemiologist, defeated U.S. Rep. Haley Stevens, a moderate Democrat, by a narrow margin Wednesday after a long and intense campaign that was seen as a proxy for the party’s fis-

tures.

The race was far closer than some polls had indicated. El-Sayed was leading Stevens by 15,000 votes, about 1 percentage point, with 99% of votes counted Wednesday, according to the Associated Press.

El-Sayed will face former Rep. Mike Rogers, a Republican, in the general election. The winner will succeed retiring Democratic Sen. Gary Peters, whose seat Democrats see as critical to retain for the party to have a chance at flipping the Senate.

“We’ve got an opportunity to bring ourselves back together, to come together around a movement, to take our democracy back,” El-Sayed said Wednesday on MSNOWN’s “Morning Joe.”

El-Sayed’s victory will put to the test in a swing state the broader strength of the progressive movement, which has found success in deep-blue places like New York City, where Zohran Mamdani was elected mayor last year, and Los Angeles, where City Councilmember Nithya Raman is locked in a tight race mayoral contest with incumbent Karen Bass. Both Mamdani

[See **Democrats**, A6]

Lineage estimates steep cleanup cost

Warehouse operator expects to spend up to \$100 million for Boyle Heights fire mop-up.

By TONY BRISCOE AND ALEX WIGGLESWORTH

As air quality regulators press for legal action against the operator of a cold storage warehouse that burned in Boyle Heights, Lineage officials say they expect to spend \$80 million to \$100 million to clean up the site, which contains millions of pounds of rotting meat and has generated thousands of odor complaints.

Lineage officials released their cost estimate for cleanup hours before they were scheduled to appear before the South Coast Air Quality Management District Hearing Board on Wednesday. Among other actions, the board was set to consider demands for a legal order against Lineage that would compel the company to take dozens of additional steps to mitigate the stench and vermin that have been attracted to the site.

Since Lineage’s 500,000-square-foot warehouse caught fire June 17, the South Coast Air Quality Management District has received more than 4,000 odor complaints and has issued Lineage at least 20 violation notices for public nuisance.

On Wednesday, air district attorneys petitioned the agency’s five-member hearing board to approve more than 80 new requirements related to ongoing remediation. Local regulators are calling for:

- The removal of at least 8.8 million pounds of food waste each week.
- Waste to be loaded only through the south loading dock, which is farthest from homes.
- The operation of an odor-neutralizing misting system around the warehouse and any openings.
- A plan for wastewater collection and storage.
- A public notification system to update residents on the cleanup progress and activities that could result in an increase in odors.

[See **Lineage**, A7]



JESSIE ALCHEH Associated Press

DOUBLE LOSS FOR DODGERS

Despite two homers by Shohei Ohtani, they fall at Chicago for sixth straight defeat after bad news on Dalton Rushing’s injury. **SPORTS, B10**

Rocket’s one-way trip to the stars

Scientists believe that SpaceX’s spent second stage has struck the moon, forging a crater 60 feet wide. **NATION, A4**

Weather Mostly sunny. L.A. Basin: 87/68. **B6**

Markets **A11**
Opinion Voices **A12**

Early-education program changes

U.S. proposes revamp of Head Start, raising anxiety for families. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

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